SOWING SEEDS OF SOVEREIGNTY

HOW BRICS+ CAN EMPOWER RURAL COMMUNITIES THROUGH SUSTAINABLE AGRICULTURE

John Nyambane, Sociologist & Researcher, and Wasseem Emam, Founder of Ethical Seafood Research

Reclaiming food sovereignty in the Global South

Across the Global South, rural communities are reclaiming agency over their food systems amid intersecting crises of climate change, food insecurity, inequality, and geopolitical realignment. As BRICS+ emerges as a counterweight to Western-dominated development paradigms, its potential to reshape agricultural cooperation is profound. By linking innovation, finance, and localised governance, BRICS+ can strengthen the resilience of smallholder farmers who remain the backbone of food systems across Africa and the Global South.

In the heart of rural African countries such as Kenya, smallholder farmers live a paradox emblematic of the Global South, regions blessed with agricultural abundance yet plagued by chronic vulnerability. Despite months of careful cultivation, farmers routinely lose significant portions of their harvests to inadequate storage, limited market access, and climate-induced shocks. Recent data show that nearly 30–40% of Kenya's post-harvest yield is lost each year due to poor infrastructure and minimal technological integration. These persistent challenges perpetuate cycles of food insecurity, rural poverty, and dependency, diminishing Kenya's capacity to achieve agricultural self-sufficiency and economic sovereignty.

This reality is not unique to Kenya. Across Latin America, South Asia, and Sub-Saharan Africa, structural inequalities in trade, financing, and climate resilience have constrained local production systems and weakened national autonomy over food resources. The paradox lies in the fact that these same regions, rich in fertile land and human capital, collectively produce a large share of the world's agricultural commodities while remaining net importers of essential food products. Such dependency illustrates the enduring asymmetries of the global agricultural order, where the Global South remains entangled in unequal value chains dominated by industrialised economies.

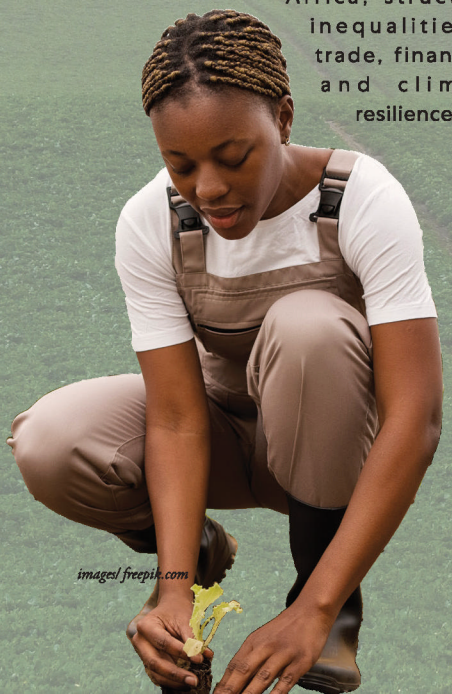


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In this evolving framework, sovereignty is not limited to national self-sufficiency but encompasses local empowerment, gender inclusivity, and the revitalisation of indigenous agricultural knowledge systems. In Kenya, where women represent over 65% of the agricultural workforce, sovereignty entails reconfiguring access to resources, markets, and adaptive technologies that can enhance resilience and productivity.

The transformative role of BRICS+ in agricultural resilience

BRICS+ can play a catalytic role in this transformation through South–South cooperation — facilitating technology transfer, climate-resilient investment, and capacity-building initiatives that address the intersecting challenges of food insecurity and economic dependency. The New Development Bank (NDB), as the financial arm of BRICS+, provides a mechanism for channelling sustainable agricultural financing, particularly for smallholder farmers and rural enterprises.

For Kenya and similar economies, participation in these platforms could yield multiple benefits. It could facilitate technology transfer for precision farming, cold storage, and irrigation systems; enable South–South market linkages that reduce dependency on Western export markets; and strengthen food system governance by integrating local policy frameworks with global value-chain reforms. Successful examples from Brazil's Fome Zero (Zero Hunger) programme and India's digital agriculture initiatives demonstrate viable models adaptable to Kenya's devolved governance structure.

In essence, the agricultural paradox of the Global South demands a paradigm shift - from dependency-driven food security to sovereignty-centred sustainability. BRICS+ presents not just an economic alliance but a political opportunity to rewrite the narrative of rural resilience in Kenya, where sovereignty begins not in the halls of global summits but in the fields where farmers sow the seeds of a self-reliant future.

The way forward

Four policy strategies to operationalise a sovereignty-based model in Africa's agriculture sector include localised investment mechanisms, knowledge co-production, inclusive governance, and digital transformation. The NDB should prioritise concessional financing for smallholder-led agriculture, establishing regional BRICS+ agroecology hubs, integrating food sovereignty principles into African countries' agricultural policy, and expanding access to agri-tech platforms through public-private partnerships.

Africa's food security needs a shift from technocratic interventions to adaptive governance systems that value local agency and ecological sustainability. Resilient countries embed food systems within socio-ecological realities, not just productivity indicators. African's experience emphasises the need for multi-scalar collaboration, bridging global frameworks with local institutions. Future research should use longitudinal and spatial data to trace local adaptation's mediating role in food insecurity outcomes under climate stress.

The future of food security across the Global South lies not just in increasing food production but in reclaiming the right to produce on their own terms. BRICS+ presents a promising framework through which rural communities can shift from dependency to dignity.

By integrating finance, technology, and local knowledge, BRICS+ can help cultivate the seeds of sovereignty across Africa's smallholder landscapes. The African experience serves as a microcosm of what a post-Western agricultural order might resemble: decentralised, cooperative, and grounded in ecological justice. This shift not only promises to enhance food security but also empowers communities to define their own agricultural futures, free from the constraints of traditional, top-down models of development.